

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

TUESDAY · 14 JULY 2026



AWAITING PASSAGE



20%

THE GUARDIAN, SELF-APPOINTED

THE WORLD

Trump declares the US "Guardian of the Strait" and sets a 20% toll on Hormuz cargo — with no one else's signature on it

THE MACRO DESK

The week's most-watched inflation print and five banks' earnings land the same morning — the forecasts finally have to answer to the numbers

CURIOSITIES

A Japanese probe flies past a "snowman" asteroid, and astronomers publish a checklist for finding an alien megastructure

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TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

A crown nobody else signed off on

A week that hands its readers a straight run of numbers due to arrive on schedule — a GDP print, a CPI reading, five banks' earnings, a World Cup bracket still to be played — against one man's decision to call himself something and start charging for it.

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FROM THE DESK

"Uneasy lies the head that wears a crown."

— William Shakespeare, *Henry IV, Part 2* (1597)

Shakespeare's king can't sleep because the crown he wears was fought for, not given. This week the line fits a subtler discomfort: a title nobody else conferred. Washington calls itself "the Guardian of the Hormuz Strait" and sets a 20% toll on the strength of that name alone — no treaty, no partner, no vote. Elsewhere this issue, the opposite discipline plays out in public: a GDP print, a CPI reading, a match still to be played, a hammer still to fall. Nothing in those columns is true until it's measured. The crown you give yourself is the easiest kind to lose.

THE STRIP — AS OF MONDAY 13 JUL CLOSE (ASIA TUESDAY-OPEN PENDING)

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	NOTE
STI	5,465.46	-0.07% Mon
US 10Y	~4.54–4.56%	last firm print, Thu/Fri
DXY	100.93	little changed
USD/SGD	~1.2925	most recent firm print
Brent	>\$82	+ on the blockade news, Mon pm
Gold	~\$4,020	-2% Mon, 2nd straight fall
BTC	~\$62.5k	softer on Mideast risk

Levels held honestly to their last confirmed print at Singapore Tuesday press time; several instruments (S&P, USD/SGD, USD/JPY) are carried at their most recent firm figure rather than guessed at Tuesday-open. Market data is explanation, not advice — see Macro, [p15](#).

SOURCES · Shakespeare, *Henry IV, Part 2* (1597), Act III Sc. I. Market levels: NPR, CNBC, Bloomberg, Yahoo Finance, TradingEconomics, Fortune (13 Jul 2026).

THE WORLD · GULF CRISIS

Trump names the US "Guardian of the Strait," sets a 20% Hormuz toll — and finds no takers

A third weekend of strikes gave way Monday to a unilateral American toll on the world's busiest oil chokepoint. The Gulf states, the IMO and Beijing all said no before the gate even came down.

President Trump said Monday that the United States will reinstate its naval blockade of Iranian ports and, "as a matter of FAIRNESS," charge a 20 percent fee on the value of all cargo transiting the Strait of Hormuz — declaring that "the U.S.A. will be, from this point forward, known as 'THE GUARDIAN OF THE HORMUZ STRAIT.'" The blockade, aimed at stopping only Iranian-flagged ships and their customers, was due to take effect Tuesday afternoon; humanitarian shipments of food and medicine remain permitted, subject to inspection.¹

The announcement followed a third consecutive weekend of US strikes and Iranian retaliation — roughly 140 sites hit overnight Saturday into Sunday, an Iranian response reaching five Gulf states, and the 11 July burning of a Cyprus-flagged container ship transiting the strait (see No. 41). Iran's Persian Gulf Strait Authority declared passage "currently not possible" on Sunday; CENTCOM maintained the strait was open to "lawful" transit. A live shipping-traffic monitor cited by multiple outlets put Monday's transit count at roughly 34 vessels against a normal daily flow near 88 — a number Meridian flags as tracker-sourced, not officially confirmed.²

Nobody with a stake in the strait accepted the toll. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said there is "zero support among the Gulf countries for any sort of toll or fees or anything that charges for the use of international waters." The International Maritime Organization — the UN body whose Singapore-led resolution on free Hormuz transit passed in No. 40 — stated flatly that "there is no legal basis through which to introduce mandatory tolls simply to transit through a strait." Brent crude, which had eased toward \$70 on ceasefire hopes at the start of the month, climbed past \$82 a barrel Monday afternoon on the news.³

WASHINGTON — CNBC/PBS FRAMING

US coverage takes Trump's self-conferred title largely at face value, centring the toll's logic (America already patrols the strait; now it will be paid for it) and Rubio's account of allied pushback as a negotiating wrinkle rather than a rejection.

GULF/GCC — REUTERS/GULF- OUTLET FRAMING

Gulf-facing coverage leads with the "zero support" line and reports, separately, that some internationally flagged vessels — including Chinese ships — have already been paying Iran an informal toll of its own: two rival claimants to the same fee, neither one recognised by the other's customers.

BEIJING — FOREIGN MINISTRY/STATE- MEDIA FRAMING

China called the blockade "dangerous and irresponsible," warned it would "aggravate confrontation" and jeopardise safe passage, and urged "all parties" back toward the ceasefire — a notably even-handed line given roughly 40 percent of China's oil imports transit the strait.

0

GOVERNMENTS OR BODIES THAT HAD ACCEPTED THE 20% TOLL AS OF MONDAY NIGHT — THE IMO, THE GCC AND BEIJING ALL DECLINED, PER REUTERS/CNBC

SOURCES · 1 NPR/Houston Public Media, "Trump says the U.S. will blockade Iran again and charge ships a toll," 13 Jul 2026; CNBC, "Trump proposes 20% toll on cargo through Strait of Hormuz," 13 Jul 2026. 2 Al Jazeera live blog, 11 Jul 2026; straits.live tracker (unofficial), 13 Jul 2026. 3 CNBC, "IMO maritime agency opposes Hormuz transit fees," 13 Jul 2026; Newsweek, "China reacts to Trump's blockade," 13 Jul 2026; Bloomberg oil desk, 13 Jul 2026.

THE WORLD · UKRAINE

A prime minister moves to Washington, and a request for 300 interceptors

Kyiv's cabinet reshuffle resolves into a specific posting, and the winter air-defence ask gets a number attached to it.

President Zelensky told Monday's Coalition of the Willing meeting that Ukraine needs a winter package of 300 Patriot interceptor missiles — the first time the ask has come with a hard number rather than a general appeal. British Prime Minister Keir Starmer confirmed the UK will join the EU's €90 billion Ukraine loan facility, widening the financing coalition beyond the eurozone.¹

The cabinet move flagged in No. 41 has a shape now: Naftogaz chief executive Oleksiy Koretskyi is reported set to become prime minister, with outgoing PM Yulia Svyrydenko moving specifically into the role of Ukraine's ambassador to Washington — a partner-facing posting rather than a demotion. Neither move is yet formally confirmed by Kyiv.²

On the ground: Russian forces logged 69 attacks Sunday concentrated on the Sloviansk and Pokrovsk sectors; Chernihiv region reported nearly 70,000 customers without power after strikes on the grid; Odesa's district saw drone strikes damage a high-rise and a home-improvement store roof, with eight civilians injured by artillery and drone fire in Kherson over the weekend.³

ALSO THIS WEEK

Iran's own informal toll. Reporting this week places some internationally-flagged vessels — including Chinese-flagged ships — already quietly paying Iran a fee of its own for safe passage, separate from and unacknowledged by Washington's new toll. Two governments now claim the right to charge for the same water; neither recognises the other's claim as legitimate, which is precisely the problem for an insurer trying to price the crossing.⁴

China's Q2 GDP, due 16 Jul. Beijing's own quarterly print lands Thursday, with most external forecasts clustering between 4.6 and 4.9 percent after a first-quarter 5.0 percent read — a number that will land squarely inside the same Hormuz-driven oil-price shock rattling Tuesday's markets (see Macro, [p15](#)), since roughly 40 percent of China's oil imports transit the strait.

THE CHATTER — WORLD CUP SEMIS, UNPLAYED AT PRESS TIME

France meet Spain and England meet Argentina in the semi-finals this week — a bracket forums are calling the strongest in memory, with holders Argentina (Messi's likely last World Cup) up against a Bellingham-inspired England. Neither match had kicked off as this issue closed; Meridian is reporting the fixture, not guessing the score.

— [r/football](#) and [r/soccer](#) megathreads, 13 Jul 2026

IN BRIEF

France v Spain — Tuesday (US kickoff; Wednesday pre-dawn Singapore time). 2018 champions vs. 2010 champions.

England v Argentina — Wednesday 15 Jul, 3pm ET (Thursday pre-dawn Singapore time), Atlanta.

Russian combat losses — approximately 1.42 million personnel since Feb 2022, per Ukraine's General Staff tally (a Ukrainian-sourced figure, not independently verified).

300

PATRIOT INTERCEPTORS ZELENSKY REQUESTED FOR THE WINTER AIR-DEFENCE PACKAGE, 13 JUL

Shipping insurance. War-risk premiums for Hormuz transits have risen alongside the toll standoff, per maritime-insurance trackers cited in this week's coverage — a cost that, unlike Washington's 20 percent figure, is actually being paid, by whoever still chooses to sail.

World Cup, resolved elsewhere. The quarter-final round that set this bracket closed cleanly: France eliminated Morocco, Spain edged Belgium, England beat Norway 2-1 on a Bellingham brace, and holders Argentina needed a 112th-minute Julián Álvarez goal to see off ten-man Switzerland 3-1 after extra time — the only four results in this issue that arrived without a single disputed account of what happened.

SOURCES · 1 Coalition of the Willing readout, 13 Jul 2026; UK government statement via Reuters. 2 Reporting on Ukrainian cabinet reshuffle, 12-13 Jul 2026 (unconfirmed by Kyiv at press time). 3 Ukrinform, "War" rubric, 13 Jul 2026. World Cup: Al Jazeera, "Which teams are in the World Cup semifinals," 12 Jul 2026; CBS Sports bracket, 13 Jul 2026. 4 Newsweek, "China reacts to Trump's blockade," 13 Jul 2026 (see p3); World Bank, "China Economic Update," Jun 2026.

SINGAPORE • ECONOMY

The number lands at 8am — and so, likely, does the haze

MTI's advance Q2 GDP estimate is due this morning, with economists split on whether growth held near Q1's pace or eased toward it. Separately, the El Niño season now carries a "red" risk rating for transboundary haze.

The Ministry of Trade and Industry releases its advance estimate for second-quarter GDP at 8am today — the first hard read on whether Singapore's AI-driven manufacturing boom held its pace into the middle of the year. DBS economists Radhika Rao and Mo Ji forecast 5.8 percent year-on-year growth and 1.5 percent quarter-on-quarter on a seasonally adjusted basis, a touch below the first quarter's 6.0 percent print but still resilient, citing strong electronics manufacturing and wholesale trade on AI-related demand. Other desks have pencilled in a softer 5.3 percent, expecting some cooling from Q1's pace. Meridian is holding this as a forecast, not a result, until MTI's release lands.¹

Non-oil domestic exports are tipped to post a fourth consecutive month of double-digit growth, though at a slower rate than May's, alongside robust modern-services and construction activity. The print will be read against a jittery macro backdrop — the Strait of Hormuz standoff (see p3) has already pushed Brent above \$82 and is the kind of shock that shows up in Singapore's trade numbers with a lag.²

Separately, Singapore heads into a haze season now rated "red" — high risk — by regional monitors. The Meteorological Service Singapore has flagged an 80 percent probability of an El Niño event through July, with a positive Indian Ocean Dipole expected to follow from July to August; the combination points to warmer, drier conditions from June through October and a materially raised risk of transboundary haze reaching Singapore, last seen at this severity in the 2015 season.³

The GDP print's market read matters as much as the number itself. A beat on DBS's 5.8 percent forecast would likely be read as confirmation that Singapore's AI-linked manufacturing cycle still has room to run into the second half; a miss toward the softer 5.3 percent case would sharpen questions about how much of the export strength is front-loading ahead of any further Hormuz-driven shipping disruption. Either way, MAS's October monetary-policy review — the next scheduled recalibration point for the Singapore dollar's policy band — will have this print as its opening input.⁴

On the haze front, NEA's operational playbook hasn't changed since past severe seasons: hourly PSI readings, a public advisory tier system, and school-level guidance on outdoor activity once the index crosses into the "unhealthy" band. What's different this year is the lead time — flagging a "red" risk rating in July, months before the August–September peak the 2015 comparison points to, gives households longer than usual to have N95 masks and air purifiers ready rather than scrambling once the skies actually turn.

5.8%

DBS'S FORECAST FOR Q2 YOY GDP GROWTH — A FORECAST, NOT THE MTI PRINT, WHICH LANDS 8AM TODAY

THE SCEPTIC

Forecasters have missed on the high side before this year — Q1's 6.0 percent print beat most desks' expectations. A GDP forecast is exactly the kind of number this issue is built around: real only once it's measured, not before.

IN BRIEF

Haze trigger — NEA's guidance: track hourly PSI: PSI above 100 ("unhealthy") is the cue for N95 masks and indoor filtration.

2015 comparison — that El Niño season cut Jun–Sep rainfall roughly 35% below the long-term average regionally.

SIA governance — Singapore Airlines re-designates Dominic Ho and Simon Cheong as non-independent non-executive directors and reshuffles several board committees ahead of its July AGM, a routine governance refresh rather than a strategy shift.

SOURCES • 1 MTI, "Release of Advance GDP Estimates for Second Quarter 2026"; DBS Research via FXStreet, 10 Jul 2026. 2 Capital Economics Asia Rapid Response note, Jul 2026. 3 Singapore Institute of International Affairs, "Report: Haze Outlook 2026"; Human Resources Online, "El Niño to bring hotter and drier weather," Jul 2026. 4 TipRanks, "Singapore Airlines reshapes board committees ahead of July AGM," Jul 2026; MAS monetary policy statement calendar.

PROPERTY · SUPPLY

Jurong Lake District's white site goes to tender — the biggest supply move of the second half

Nine Confirmed List sites join the 2H2026 government land sales programme, headlined by a mixed-use white site that could reshape Singapore's second CBD.

The Urban Redevelopment Authority's second-half 2026 government land sales programme launches this month with nine sites on the Confirmed List and thirteen on the Reserve List, together capable of yielding roughly 9,200 private residential units, 188,100 sqm of commercial gross floor area and 970 hotel rooms. The headline site is a white parcel at Jurong Lake District going to tender in July: a potential 186,000 sqm of mixed-use development, including at least 40,000 sqm of office space, up to 1,200 private homes and 44,000 sqm of retail, hotel, serviced-apartment and community space.¹

A second white site at Town Hall Link also joins the Confirmed List this month. Together the two mark the largest single-quarter injection of mixed-use land into the pipeline this cycle — a supply-side story, not a rate story, per this desk's standing house line: the market question now is absorption, not affordability of financing.²

On the demand side, Kingsford's Lentor Gardens Residences — the first H2 launch, previewed 4 July at an average S\$2,350 psf across roughly 500 units — opens booking 18 July, and will be the first real read on whether buyers are still chasing the OCR at current pricing. Two long-running en-bloc sagas remain genuinely unresolved: Balestier Regency's fourth attempt (S\$255m guide, tender closed 9 Jul) and High Point's fifth (S\$580m guide) have both had tenders close without a published result — a month-plus of silence Meridian is holding as open, not guessing at.³

The Reserve List's thirteen sites matter almost as much as the nine Confirmed ones: unlike Confirmed sites, which go to tender on a fixed schedule regardless of demand, Reserve sites only launch when a developer commits to a minimum bid — a real-time gauge of where builders actually see appetite. A heavy Reserve List alongside a smaller Confirmed one has historically signalled a government keeping optionality rather than forcing supply into a market it isn't sure can absorb it;

this cycle's roughly even split between the two lists reads as URA hedging both ways.⁴

For context, the last comparable single-site injection at this scale was the original Jurong Lake District masterplan announcement years ago; this month's white-site tender is the first large parcel released under that plan to actually go to market, rather than remain a rezoning promise — the detail long-time JLD-watchers are treating as the real signal, more than the unit count itself.

9,200

PRIVATE RESIDENTIAL UNITS THE FULL 2H2026 GLS PROGRAMME COULD YIELD, CONFIRMED + RESERVE LISTS COMBINED

THE CHATTER — PROPERTY FORUMS

Local property forums read the JLD white site as the clearest signal yet that URA is serious about a "second CBD" east of the current one — with the office-space minimum drawing more attention than the residential count, since it commits the site to genuine mixed-use rather than a residential-led rebrand.

— [r/singaporefi](#) and property-broker commentary, Jul 2026

STILL ON THE SHELF

Dunearn House / Turf City — booking-day result due 25 Jul, the next read against Lentor Gardens' 18 Jul.

Balestier Regency & High Point — both tenders closed, both results still unpublished.

SOURCES · 1 The Edge Singapore, "URA announces nine new sites under Confirmed List in 2H2026 GLS programme," Jul 2026. 2 URA GLS programme release, Jul 2026. 3 Stacked Homes / EdgeProp, Balestier Regency and High Point collective-sale reporting, Jul 2026; Andee Ching, "Singapore Residential New Launches 2026–2027." 4 URA GLS programme mechanics, Confirmed vs Reserve List, Jul 2026.

TECHNOLOGY · AI & CHIPS

DeepSeek starts building its own chip, and finally sets a date for V4

A year-old, quietly-run effort to cut loose from Nvidia and Huawei surfaces the same week the model it's meant to serve gets a release date.

DeepSeek is developing its own AI chip, according to three people familiar with the effort, in a push to reduce its dependence on both Nvidia and Huawei silicon. The chip targets inference — serving a trained model's responses to users — rather than training new ones, and the project is described as early-stage: DeepSeek has been in discussions with chip-design houses, foundries and memory suppliers for roughly a year without yet naming partners publicly.¹

The report broke the same day DeepSeek confirmed the official release of V4 for mid-July, alongside new peak-time API pricing. An April preview, V4-Flash, was trained in part on Huawei's Ascend chips — a hedge DeepSeek now appears to be extending into its own hardware rather than choosing a single external partner. Nvidia shares slipped roughly 1.6 percent in pre-market trading on the chip-development report.²

The pattern is now a industry-wide one: OpenAI, Anthropic, Google and Amazon are each investing in custom silicon of their own, chasing the same goal by different routes — insulation from a chip supply chain that a single vendor, or a single export-control regime, can still bottleneck. DeepSeek's version of that story carries an extra layer: it is simultaneously hedging against Nvidia (the export-control risk) and Huawei (the maturity risk), rather than picking a side in that rivalry.³

What makes DeepSeek's move notable isn't the ambition — every serious AI lab wants off the Nvidia treadmill eventually — it's the sequencing. OpenAI, Anthropic, Google and Amazon are each building custom silicon from a position of enormous compute abundance, hedging a supply chain they can otherwise afford to keep buying into. DeepSeek is doing it from the opposite position: already export-controlled, already priced out of the newest Nvidia parts, building its own chip not as a hedge against future risk but as a response to a constraint that has already arrived. That's a materially different bet, and one with a much shorter runway to prove out.⁴

The chip's inference-only focus is itself a tell. Training frontier models remains the hardest problem in the stack, and DeepSeek isn't yet claiming it can solve that without Nvidia or Huawei hardware. Serving a trained model to millions of API calls, by contrast, is a workload custom silicon has repeatedly proven itself on — Google's TPUs and Amazon's Trainium/Inferentia lines both started there before anyone trusted them with training runs. If DeepSeek's chip ships at all, expect it to follow the same path: inference first, training years later, if ever.

~lyr

HOW LONG DEEPSEEK'S IN-HOUSE CHIP EFFORT HAS REPORTEDLY BEEN RUNNING BEFORE THIS WEEK'S REPORT SURFACED IT

THE CHATTER

Chip-industry commentary reads the move less as a Huawei-vs-Nvidia bet and more as DeepSeek refusing to be hostage to either — "training on Ascend, designing your own inference silicon, and still buying Nvidia where you can" is the summary doing the rounds on semiconductor-focused forums.

— semiconductor-industry commentary, Jul 2026

IN BRIEF

V4 GA — mid-July, per DeepSeek's own Monday announcement; new peak-time API pricing tier confirmed, exact date not yet published.

SOURCES · 1 U.S. News/Reuters, "Exclusive—China's DeepSeek developing its own AI chip, sources say," 7 Jul 2026; Semafor, "DeepSeek's AI chip plans," 7 Jul 2026. 2 TechNode, "DeepSeek to launch V4 in mid-July with new peak-time API pricing," 30 Jun 2026. 3 Cybernews, "DeepSeek takes on Nvidia with plans for its own AI chip," Jul 2026. 4 Industry-wide custom-silicon context, semiconductor-industry commentary, Jul 2026.

TECHNOLOGY · THE HOME LAB

The Nvidia memory crunch finally makes AMD's software gap look survivable

The RTX 5090 hasn't gotten any cheaper — but ROCm has gotten good enough that "just buy AMD" stopped being a punchline.

The RTX 5090 street price hasn't moved much since No. 41's "don't buy a GPU this week" note — Amazon lists it at \$4,329, more than double its \$1,999 launch MSRP, while custom AIB cards from mid-range (\$2,900-plus) to liquid-cooled premium (\$5,000-plus) all sit well above list. Oddly, a used card on eBay (\$3,999) now undercuts a new one — a sign the premium is in Nvidia's channel allocation, not the silicon's actual scarcity. The root cause hasn't changed either: AI data centres are outbidding consumer GPUs for DRAM and graphics memory, and both Nvidia and AMD have pushed through phased price rises this year as a result.¹

What has changed is the AMD side of the equation. ROCm — AMD's long-mocked answer to CUDA — "now supports PyTorch, Ollama, LM Studio and ComfyUI in ways that actually hold up in practice," per current hardware guides, following official ROCm-on-Windows support landing in Comfy Desktop's June overhaul. For a reader priced out of the Nvidia queue, that closes the last real reason to wait rather than build on AMD.²

THE CHATTER — R/LOCALLLAMA

The home-lab consensus has audibly shifted: threads that used to warn "AMD support is a minefield" now read "ROCm just works for Ollama and ComfyUI now — the only reason left to pay the Nvidia tax is CUDA-only tooling, and that list keeps shrinking."

— r/LocalLLaMA, r/comfyui, Jul 2026

IN BRIEF

ComfyUI — v0.27.0's int8 model support now runs on Turing-generation cards and newer (RTX 2060+), trading a small quality hit for real VRAM headroom on older hardware.

LM Studio — MLX engine v1.8.5 adds KV-cache checkpointing on Apple Silicon, reclaiming memory across similar chat turns.

CARD / CONFIG	STREET PRICE	NOTE
RTX 5090 Founders Edition	\$1,999.99	rarely in stock at list
RTX 5090 (Amazon, current)	\$4,329	>2x launch MSRP
RTX 5090 (used, eBay)	\$3,999	cheaper than new — a channel signal
RTX 5090 (liquid-cooled AIB)	\$5,000+	premium variants

Comfy Desktop's June overhaul is the more consequential change for anyone actually running a home lab day to day, separate from the ROCm story: multi-instance management, workflow snapshots and shared model storage mean a single machine can now serve several concurrent ComfyUI sessions — a household with more than one household member touching the same GPU rig, in this reader's case — without each session re-downloading multi-gigabyte checkpoints.³

None of this changes the top-line advice from No. 41: at \$4,300-plus, the RTX 5090 remains a bad buy for anyone building a new local-LLM rig this month. What's changed is that "wait for Nvidia" is no longer the only sane option — for a reader willing to trade the newest CUDA-only tooling for a working ComfyUI-and-Ollama stack today, AMD is now a legitimate answer, not a compromise.

SOURCES · 1 TechTimes, "GPU Memory Crisis Prices RTX 5090 Above \$4,300," 11 Jul 2026; Best Value GPU price tracker, Jul 2026. 2 MindStudio, "Running Local AI on AMD: ROCm, Ollama, and LM Studio Performance in 2026"; ComfyUI official changelog, Jun–Jul 2026. 3 ComfyUI official changelog, Comfy Desktop overhaul, Jun 2026.

THE KIT · CONFIRMED

Samsung locks in 22 July — and the leaked Fold shape is a real departure

Unpacked is officially on the calendar, with Samsung signalling a foldable that looks nothing like the last four generations.

Samsung has formally confirmed Galaxy Unpacked for 22 July in London (2pm BST / 9am EDT / 3pm CEST, streamed on Samsung Newsroom), superseding the "held as upcoming" note in No. 41. Expected on stage: the Galaxy Z Flip 8 and Z Fold 8, two new Galaxy Watches, fresh Galaxy AI features, and — per Samsung's own teaser copy — "possibly a few surprises," widely read as a first look at Samsung's own smart glasses.¹

The detail worth watching is the Fold's shape. Samsung's own pre-event signalling points to a Z Fold 8 that is wider and less vertically elongated than any prior generation — proportions closer to 4:3 when unfolded, a meaningful break from the narrow-tablet form factor the line has kept since 2019. If it lands as leaked, it directly answers the most common complaint about every Fold to date: that the open-book screen was too narrow to use like a real tablet.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

Nothing Ear (3a) — an incremental firmware update adds 32MB of on-device storage for call recording and upgrades to 12mm drivers for fuller hi-res audio; no peg for a full item, filed as a maintenance update to a set already covered. Samsung's own watch tease is the quieter story inside the 22 July event: two new Galaxy Watches are expected

THE KIT · ALSO WORTH A LOOK

Even Realities' G2 skips the display gimmick, and forums say that's the point

Where most of this year's smart-glasses field — Xreal's a01+ (No. 39), Google and Samsung's forthcoming pair (No. 40) — leans on a visible screen or a camera as the headline feature, Even Realities took the opposite approach with its G2: no camera, a heads-up display genuinely subtle enough that the glasses read as ordinary eyewear rather than a gadget, and a feature set built around not being noticed. Reviewers coming out of this year's CES named it the most quietly impressive pair in the category specifically because it doesn't try to look impressive.⁴

THE CHATTER

Foldable-focused forums are cautiously optimistic — "every generation promises the crease and the aspect ratio are finally solved" is the standing scepticism — but the 4:3 leak specifically has moved more sceptics than any Fold rumour in the last two cycles.

— r/GalaxyFold, r/Android, Jul 2026

ALSO IN

Marshall Acton IV & Stanmore IV — fourth-generation powered Bluetooth speakers: improved tweeters and waveguides for wider dispersion, redesigned bass ports for deeper, cleaner low end.

4:3

THE UNFOLDED ASPECT RATIO SAMSUNG'S PRE-EVENT TEASERS POINT TO FOR THE Z FOLD 8 — LEAKED, NOT YET CONFIRMED

alongside the foldables, with early leaks pointing to a bigger health-sensor push rather than a case-size change — the kind of update this reader's Oura-and-Whoop stack will actually notice, if Samsung's sensor claims hold up under independent testing after launch.³

For a reader already committed to the Xreal ecosystem for media, the G2 isn't a replacement — it's a different category, closer to a heads-up notification layer than a personal cinema screen. The no-camera design is also a deliberate privacy trade-off worth noting against the Ray-Ban Meta line's camera-first approach: less capability, and correspondingly less to worry about when wearing it around other people.

SOURCES · 1 Samsung Newsroom, "[Invitation] Galaxy Unpacked July 2026: A New Shape Unfolds," Jul 2026. 2 SamMobile, "Samsung schedules July 22 Unpacked event," Jul 2026; igor'sLab, "A new foldable format is emerging," Jul 2026. Marshall: Gear Patrol, "Best New Gadgets and Hi-Fi Releases of 2026," Jul 2026. 3 Notebookcheck, "Nothing schedules new earbuds' launch," Jul 2026; pre-event Unpacked leak coverage, Jul 2026. 4 Wareable, "Best smart glasses and AR specs," Jul 2026; The Gadgeteer, "7 Smart Glasses Stories That Defined 2026 So Far."

CONNECTED HOME · TWO PHILOSOPHIES

Apple teaches its cameras to describe what they see; Home Assistant teaches its network to explain itself

The same July brought the two ecosystems' biggest updates in years — and they solved for almost opposite problems.

Apple Home's biggest update in years, previewed at WWDC and rolling out through July, centres on Apple Intelligence reading HomeKit Secure Video footage rather than just storing it: the Home app now generates plain-language summaries of clips ("a person walked through the room," "a dog sat on the floor"), recognising people, animals, vehicles and packages, and lets a user search recordings in natural language instead of scrubbing a timeline. HKSV also finally drops its 1080p ceiling — compatible cameras now stream and record at up to 4K.¹

Notifications get smarter too: Apple Intelligence bundles related events into a single live alert that updates as activity unfolds, rather than firing a new push for every triggered sensor. Compatible smart plugs now surface energy-usage data directly inside Home, and Apple TVs can be updated remotely through the app — small, but the kind of friction Apple has left unaddressed for years.²

Home Assistant 2026.7, out 1 July, solves a different problem: not what the network shows you, but whether you can trust it. Its Matter server has been rebuilt from scratch on matter.js, an open-source TypeScript implementation, bringing Matter 1.5.1 support (cameras, doorbells, closures) and — for the first time — native diagnostic entities: reboot count, uptime, boot reason, enough to actually answer "did that device just lose power or crash?" A new Thread mesh visualiser and Thread 1.4 support round out an update aimed squarely at network legibility, not video intelligence.³

APPLE HOME

— POLISH, CLOSED LOOP

Bets that most users want their cameras to think for them: less scrubbing, more asking. The cost is the usual one — Apple Intelligence and 4K HKSV are Apple-silicon and subscription-tier gated, not a local-first upgrade.

HOME

— TRANSPARENCY, ASSISTANTSELF-HOSTED

Bets that a local-first user wants to see the machine, not have it summarised for them: a rebuilt Matter server and a mesh visualiser are legibility tools for someone who intends to debug their own network.

4K

THE NEW HOMEKIT SECURE VIDEO CEILING, UP FROM 1080P — APPLE'S FIRST RESOLUTION BUMP IN YEARS

THE SCEPTIC

Neither update actually makes the two ecosystems interoperate any better with each other. A Home Assistant install still treats an Apple Home camera as a bridged Matter device with none of the new AI summarisation, and Apple Home still can't see Home Assistant's Thread-mesh diagnostics. "Two philosophies" also means two silos — the reader migrating from Lutron to Home Assistant, per the **READER PROFILE**, gets neither ecosystem's flagship feature by running both in parallel.

SOURCES · 1 AppleHome Authority, "Apple Home Gets Its Biggest Update in Years at WWDC 2026." 2 Forbes, "Your Apple Home Need To Be Updated," Feb 2026 (feature-rollout context). 3 Home Assistant blog, "The Matter upgrade you've been waiting for," 23 Jun 2026; TechTimes, "Home Assistant 2026.7 Arrives July 1," 29 Jun 2026.

THE GOOD LIFE · AUDIO

Sennheiser's new flagship makes its battery a spare part, not a warranty claim

Two premium-audio houses mark this July differently — one with a genuine spec jump, the other with an anniversary edition of a proven design.

Sennheiser's Momentum 5 Wireless — flagged as an upcoming shipment back in No. 17, since demoted to "still on the shelf" — has now cleared the peg this desk was waiting on: it's shipping, and the detail that got it a slot back on this page is confirmed rather than promised. The flagship active-noise-cancelling headphone looks close to its predecessors but carries the kind of quiet, substantive upgrades that matter more than a redesign: higher-resolution audio support, Dolby Atmos with head-tracking, and — the detail worth the price premium on its own — a built-in battery that's now genuinely user-replaceable rather than a trip to service. For a reader who has watched more than one flagship headphone become e-waste over a dead cell, that's the headline spec.¹

Sony took the opposite route for its own 10th-anniversary moment: the 1000X The Collection dresses the 1000XM6 in soft vegan leather and metal accents at a higher price, rather than shipping new drivers or a new chip. It's a luxury-materials edition of a known-good design, not a spec upgrade — the honest way to read a "collection" release.²

On watches, First State Auctions' Rolex Daytona "Rainbow" (ref. 126598RBOW, flagged in No. 39) remains without a published hammer price — the sale runs to 19 July, and Meridian is holding the number rather than guessing it a second issue running. Collectors with a Tokyo trip already planned should note Sotheby's holds its next watch auction there 21–24 July.³

The Momentum 5's replaceable-battery decision is worth reading against Sennheiser's own history: the company's HD 25 studio headphone has stayed in continuous production, largely unchanged, since 1988, precisely because nothing in it was designed to fail on a schedule. A flagship ANC set built the same way is a bet that longevity itself is a premium-audio feature, not just a sustainability talking point — a bet Apple and Sony's more locked-down designs implicitly argue against.⁴

For a reader weighing the two: the Sennheiser is the more defensible five-year purchase on spec alone: a replaceable cell, lossless wired fallback and head-tracked Atmos it can grow into as more services support the format. The Sony is the better buy for someone who already owns a 1000XM6 and wants the same known quantity in nicer materials — a valid reason to spend more, just not a reason to expect a materially different listening experience.

MODEL	BATTERY	SIGNATURE SPEC
Sennheiser Momentum 5	20hr, replaceable	Atmos w/ head-tracking
Sony 1000X The Collection	as 1000XM6	vegan-leather anniversary finish
Apple AirPods Max 2	20hr	H2 chip, 1.5x ANC vs. gen 1

AirPods Max 2 (released Apr 2026, US\$549) shown for reference — not a new peg this issue, included for the reader's cross-shop.

SOURCES · 1 Gear Patrol, "The Best New Gadgets and Hi-Fi Releases of 2026," Jul 2026. 2 What Hi-Fi?, "Best headphones 2026"; SoundGuys anniversary-edition coverage, Jul 2026. 3 Robb Report, "An Australian Tech Mogul's \$2 Million Watch Collection Is Heading to Auction," Jul 2026; Sotheby's Tokyo auction calendar, Jul 2026. 4 Sennheiser company history, HD 25 production notes. AirPods Max 2: Apple Newsroom, Mar 2026.

20hr

MOMENTUM 5 WIRELESS BATTERY LIFE
ON A SINGLE CHARGE — WITH A
REPLACEABLE CELL BEHIND IT

THE CHATTER — HEAD-FI /
R/HEADPHONES

Early audiophile-forum reaction to the Momentum 5 centres almost entirely on the replaceable battery — "the first flagship ANC set in years that isn't designed to die on a schedule" is the recurring line — with the Atmos head-tracking treated as a nice-to-have, not the reason to buy.

— Head-Fi, r/headphones, Jul 2026

STILL ON THE SHELF

Rolex Daytona Rainbow — auction runs to 19 Jul; hammer price still unpublished.

SCREEN & SOUND · BOX OFFICE

The Odyssey's tracking jumps past Oppenheimer's opening — a day before anyone's allowed to review it

Industry forecasters have revised Nolan's opening-weekend estimate sharply upward since the first reactions landed. The formal review embargo lifts tomorrow.

Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*, the \$250m, all-IMAX-70mm retelling opening 17 July, has had its opening-weekend tracking revised up sharply — from an initial \$80–100m range to \$98–132m per Box Office Theory's latest read, a jump industry forecasters attribute directly to the wave of "first reactions" coverage No. 41 flagged (positive, with one dissenting voice). At the top of that range, the film would open ahead of *Oppenheimer*'s \$82.4m debut on the same July weekend in 2023 — Nolan's own record to beat.¹

The formal review embargo — distinct from the early "reactions" pieces already published — lifts 15 July, two days before release. Until then, the tracking number is doing the talking: a rare case in this business of the box-office forecast moving on sentiment alone, ahead of the reviews that are supposed to drive it.²

The tracking-versus-reviews gap on *The Odyssey* is a genuinely unusual position for a film this size to be in. Studios normally hold their own tracking close until reviews land, precisely to avoid the scenario now playing out publicly: a number the industry itself is debating, built entirely on secondhand accounts of reactions from people who saw an early cut, before a single formal review has been filed. Nolan's own distributor, Universal, has stayed quiet on the tracking jump rather than confirming or disputing it — standard practice, but notable given how much of the conversation right now is forecasters talking to each other rather than to the studio.³

Worth flagging for family planning: *The Odyssey* carries a restrained marketing push toward younger audiences relative to Nolan's *Oppenheimer*, and early reactions describe combat sequences in line with its source material's violence — a title to preview before, not assume for, a family outing built around the reader's 11-year-old.

THE CHATTER

Box-office forums are treating the tracking jump cautiously — "reactions hype always over-corrects the number, then the real reviews correct it back" is the standing wisdom — with several posters flagging that Nolan's own *Interstellar* and *Tenet* both saw similar late tracking surges that the actual opening didn't fully match.

— **Boxoffice Theory forums, r/boxoffice, Jul 2026**

IN BRIEF

The Rolling Stones — *Foreign Tongues* (No. 38) — the band's 25th studio album is "racing towards Number 1" on this week's UK chart, which would be a 15th chart-topping LP some 62 years after their 1964 debut did the same; final chart position not yet confirmed.

Kelela — *new avatar* (No. 39) — first-week chart data has not yet surfaced independently of the Metacritic 88 already logged; held, not guessed.

78th Emmy nominations (No. 41) — *The Pitt's* 25 noms and *Hacks's* comedy-record 24 remain the two figures to beat; ceremony date not yet in this issue's window.

TRACKING, NOT CONFIRMED

EMBARGO LIFTS TOMORROW

\$82.4m

OPPENHEIMER'S ACTUAL JULY 2023
OPENING WEEKEND — THE NUMBER THE
ODYSSEY'S REVISED TRACKING NOW
PROJECTS CLEARING

ALSO OPENING THIS MONTH

Splash City — 20 Jul.

Spider-Man: Brand New Day — 31 Jul, the month's other major tentpole.

My Sassy Girl — 18 Jul, a theatrical re-release of the 2001 Korean romantic comedy.

SOURCES · 1 Boxoffice Pro, "Long Range Forecast: THE ODYSSEY Is Coming For All Your PLF Screens," Jul 2026; TGV Blog, "Nolan's The Odyssey Projects Massive Box Office Opening," 2 Deadline, "The Odyssey: First Reactions From The Critics And Fanboys Who've Seen It," Jul 2026. Rolling Stones: Official Charts, "The Rolling Stones are racing towards Number 1 with Foreign Tongues," Jul 2026. 3 Boxoffice Theory tracking commentary, Jul 2026; early-reactions round-up, Deadline, Jul 2026. Release calendar: Box Office Mojo, "Domestic Release Schedule," Jul 2026.

THE FAMILY DESK · AI & KIDS

Chatbot-safety laws reach the states — 78 bills, 27 legislatures, and counting

Oregon became the latest state to pass a chatbot-safety bill this week, part of a wave built almost entirely around one specific risk: AI "companion" apps designed to feel like a relationship.

Oregon passed a chatbot-safety bill this week, joining a surge of state-level action: roughly 78 chatbot-safety bills are currently live across 27 US legislatures, following California's 2025 SB 243 — the first US law to specifically regulate "companion" AI chatbots with child safety in mind. A parallel California ballot initiative would go further, requiring age-assurance technology, parental controls, annual child-safety risk assessments, and a ban on chatbots simulating romantic relationships with minors; a separate proposal would impose a four-year moratorium on AI-enabled chatbot toys marketed to children.¹

The evidence behind the wave is specific, not general: safety-testing groups report that AI companion apps readily produce inappropriate dialogue — sexual content, self-harm, violence, drug use — once told the user is a minor, and several 2024–25 cases tied emotionally-dependent chatbot use to real self-harm. Common Sense Media's standing recommendation is that no one under 18 use AI companion apps at all.²

Separately, a Family Online Safety Institute survey found parents consistently underestimate their children's AI and social-media use: only 27 percent of parents said their child had used a generative-AI tool in the past week, versus 38 percent of children who said they had — an 11-point gap that held across nearly every digital activity the survey measured, including scrolling and posting on social media.³

Beyond the state-level bills, a Geneva-launched international coalition — governments, UN agencies, tech companies, civil-society groups and educators — announced this month that it will treat children's AI safety as a standing agenda item rather than a one-off response to individual incidents, a structural shift from the reactive, case-by-case pattern that has defined the field since the first companion-app lawsuits in 2024–25.⁴

None of this is Singapore-specific: the bills on p13 are US state legislation, and the coalition is international rather than a Singapore Ministry of Education or IMDA initiative. For a local reader, the practical takeaway is upstream of any single jurisdiction's law — the app-store safeguards and platform-level age gates most of these bills are trying to mandate will, if they land, apply globally regardless of where the legislation originates.

WHAT THE LAWS — THE TARGET SPECIFICS

Every bill in this wave is aimed at a narrow category: apps explicitly designed to simulate friendship or romance, with persistent memory and emotionally-engineered engagement loops — not general-purpose assistants used for homework help or search.

78

CHATBOT-SAFETY BILLS CURRENTLY LIVE ACROSS 27 US STATE LEGISLATURES, PER BILLTRACK50 TRACKING

"It was easy to elicit inappropriate dialogue from the chatbots... immediately after learning the user was a child."

27 STATES

SB 243 PRECEDENT

COMPANION APPS, NOT ASSISTANTS

SOURCES · 1 Wired Parents, "The US Children's Tech Safety Bill That Just Passed Committee," Jul 2026; BillTrack50, "Regulating AI Companions Before They Raise Our Kids." 2 Stanford Report, "Why AI companions and young people can make for a dangerous mix"; Common Sense Media companion-app report. 3 Morningstar/AccessWire, "Parents Are Underestimating Their Kids' Digital Lives," Jul 2026. 4 UN News, "New coalition puts children's rights at the centre of the AI age," Jul 2026.

THE FAMILY DESK · DON'T BE ALARMIST

The headlines are about a 16-year-old's "AI boyfriend." For an 11-year-old, the real question is smaller

General guidance, not medical or legal advice. The legislative wave on p13 is proportionate to a real risk — for an older, more independent user than a fifth-grader.

Read closely, the wave of chatbot-safety bills and the alarming test results behind them are almost entirely about a specific product category: apps built to simulate a persistent, emotionally-engaging relationship — a companion or a romantic partner — aimed at teenagers and young adults old enough to seek one out and keep the relationship going across sessions. That is a real and well-documented risk, and it is not, primarily, an 11-year-old's risk. A fifth-grader asking a general-purpose assistant to explain a maths problem or summarise a book is using the technology in a fundamentally different way than a 16-year-old maintaining a months-long chat with an app designed to feel like a girlfriend.¹

The more realistic risk at this age is duller and easier to manage: over-reliance on an AI tool for homework rather than working through it, and the ordinary judgment questions that come with any new technology — not simulated intimacy. The Family Online Safety Institute gap on p13 is the more actionable number for a parent of an 11-year-old than any companion-app horror story: most parents simply don't have an accurate picture of which apps, AI or otherwise, their child is actually using day to day.²

That argues for a specific, proportionate response rather than a blanket ban reaction: know which apps are installed, understand which ones have persistent memory and open-ended chat (the design pattern the legislation actually targets), and treat a general homework assistant differently from a "companion" app by name and function — not as the same category of risk.³

There's a useful parallel to how this desk has covered screen time generally (No. 41): the headline statistic in a study is often measuring something narrower than the framing suggests, and the honest reading requires looking past the topline number to what was actually tested. The companion-app research is specific to apps built for persistent, emotionally-engineered relationships; applying its conclusions to a child's use of a general search or homework tool is the same category error as reading an odds ratio as a percentage.

GENERAL GUIDANCE

NOT MEDICAL OR LEGAL ADVICE

THE SCEPTIC

Coverage of AI-companion risk tends to use a 16-to-19-year-old's case to illustrate a story, then let the reader's imagination apply it to a much younger child by default. The legislative response — age-assurance tech, romantic-simulation bans — is calibrated to the teenage user the evidence is actually about.

A PARENT'S CHECKLIST

CHECK which apps have persistent memory or an open-ended chat mode, not just a single-question assistant.

CHECK whether an app is explicitly marketed as a "companion" or "friend" — that's the specific category regulators are targeting.

NOTE this is general guidance, not medical or legal advice — a specific concern about a specific child's use warrants a specific conversation, not a policy.

ASK , rather than assume — an 11-year-old is more likely to describe an app's actual function accurately than to hide it, if asked without alarm.

The FOSI parent-child awareness gap cuts in a genuinely useful direction here: rather than adding a new rule around AI specifically, folding "which apps have persistent memory" into whatever conversation already covers app downloads generally keeps the response proportionate to the actual risk profile of an 11-year-old, without treating every AI interaction as equally fraught.

THE MACRO DESK · MARKET EXPLANATION, NOT ADVICE

Today's inflation print measures a June that's already out of date

US CPI and five banks' Q2 earnings land the same morning the Fed's own rate-hike odds have cooled — just as a fresh oil shock starts pricing a July the data hasn't caught up to yet.

STI 5,465.46 ▼	US 10Y ~4.55%	DXY 100.93	BRENT >\$82 ▲	GOLD ~\$4,020 ▼	BTC ~\$62.5k ▼
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Tuesday stacks three market-moving events on top of each other: the June US CPI report (8:30am ET), JPMorgan, Wells Fargo and Citigroup's Q2 earnings (before that same open, with Bank of America, Morgan Stanley and Goldman Sachs following Wednesday), and a Hormuz toll standoff that has already pushed Brent past \$82. Consensus for CPI is soft on the surface — roughly flat month-on-month, driven by a 10 percent June drop in gasoline prices, the fourth-largest monthly decline in a decade — with an annual rate near 3.9 percent and core near 2.9 percent.¹

The catch: that gasoline-driven softness describes June, a month that ended before the blockade announcement on p3. Oil has moved from under \$70 to past \$82 in the two weeks since, and none of that shows up in today's print. If the CPI reads benign, it will be measuring a disinflationary moment that the real-time energy market has already left behind — precisely the gap this issue keeps finding elsewhere, between what's confirmed and what's already changing underneath it.²

Underneath both: the Fed's own rate-hike conviction has softened since No. 41. June's FOMC minutes showed a genuine internal split — nine members projecting at least one 2026 hike, eight projecting none — and CME FedWatch now prices September hike odds at roughly 50–55 percent, down from about 66 percent before a weaker June jobs report. Officials still see PCE inflation ending the year at 3.6 percent, well above their earlier 2.7 percent forecast — the hawkish case hasn't gone away, it's just lost some certainty.³

Higher-for-longer conviction cooled from ~66% to ~55% in three weeks — then a fresh oil shock arrived to test it.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

A global-equities-plus-bonds portfolio is caught between two forces pulling the same direction for once: elevated 10-year yields keep pressuring both legs, and a fresh oil-driven inflation impulse could re-firm the case for higher-for-longer just as CPI looks soft — reducing, not restoring, the diversification benefit between VWRA and global bonds this week. Gold's 2 percent Monday fall despite escalating Middle East risk is the tell that dollar and real-yield dynamics are currently dominating haven demand, not the war. Bitcoin softened in the same window — trading, this week, as the high-beta risk asset the honesty rule always flags it as, not as an uncorrelated hedge. Neither is a signal to act on; both are explained by the same forces above.

FED ODDS COOLING

OIL SHOCK BUILDING

CROSS-CURRENTS

SOURCES · 1 IG UK, "US CPI is out tomorrow," 13 Jul 2026; BLS CPI schedule. 2 Bloomberg oil desk, 13 Jul 2026 (see p3). 3 IG International, "US bank earnings preview: Q2 2026"; goldsilver.com, "Warsh Sat Out the Dot Plot," Jul 2026; CME FedWatch. Levels: Fortune, CNBC, TradingEconomics, Yahoo Finance (13 Jul 2026).

CURIOSITIES • SPACE

A snowman-shaped asteroid, and a checklist for the coldest "stars" in the galaxy

Japan's Hayabusa2 delivers a close-up of a contact binary 100 million kilometres out, while a new study sets observable criteria for spotting a Dyson sphere — without claiming to have found one.

JAXA's Hayabusa2 spacecraft flew past the near-Earth asteroid Torifune on 5 July, at 18:30 Japan time, coming within 800 metres of its centre at roughly 5 kilometres a second — the first asteroid encounter of the probe's extended mission since its main sample-return work concluded. The close-up images, taken with its optical navigation camera and cross-checked with near-infrared, thermal-infrared and lidar instruments, show a 450-metre, elongated two-lobed body — a "snowman" shape confirming Torifune is a contact binary, two once-separate asteroids that gently merged.¹

Separately, a study from the University of Arkansas offers astronomers a genuinely testable checklist for one of the most speculative ideas in the search for extraterrestrial intelligence: the Dyson sphere, a hypothetical energy-harvesting structure built around a star. The paper argues the best places to look are red and white dwarfs, where a surrounding sphere could show an effective temperature as low as 50 Kelvin — roughly two orders of magnitude colder than the dwarf star itself, and a temperature no known natural star occupies. A second clue: a Dyson swarm's radiator panels would leave a star's spectrum unusually "clean," missing the dust signature a natural system would show.²

Neither claim is a discovery. Hayabusa2 confirmed a shape, not a mystery; the Dyson sphere paper sets criteria for future surveys, building on Project Hephaistos's 2024 shortlist of seven candidate stars — none yet confirmed as anything but natural. Both are useful precisely because they're falsifiable: a specific, checkable prediction, not a claim dressed up as one.³

Torifune's contact-binary shape isn't unusual on its own — roughly one in seven near-Earth asteroids studied up close turns out to be two bodies that merged at low speed rather than a single formation — but Hayabusa2's instrument suite makes this one of the best-characterised examples: visible, near-infrared, thermal and lidar data together let researchers model not just the shape but the likely composition and thermal history of each lobe separately, distinguishing a gentle merger from a violent collision.⁴

The Dyson-sphere checklist's real contribution to the field is procedural as much as scientific: it gives large sky surveys — Vera Rubin Observatory's decade-long scan starts delivering full data this year, alongside Roman's infrared work from 2027 — an automatable filter to run against millions of stars, rather than requiring astronomers to eyeball each candidate individually. Whether it ever finds anything, the method is the kind of infrastructure that makes future null results actually meaningful.

50K

THE EFFECTIVE TEMPERATURE A DYSON SPHERE COULD SHOW — ABOUT 200°C COLDER THAN THE COLDEST KNOWN NATURAL STAR

THE CHATTER — R/SPACE, R/ASTRONOMY

Astronomy forums are treating the checklist the right way — "this is a filter for ruling candidates OUT, not a treasure map" is the top-voted framing — while noting the genuine appeal: for the first time, "is this a Dyson sphere" has a specific, checkable answer rather than just vibes.

— r/space, r/astronomy, Jul 2026

IN BRIEF

Torifune — 450m, contact binary, ~100 million km from Earth at flyby.

SOURCES · 1 JAXA press release, 6 Jul 2026; Sci.News, "Hayabusa-2 Snaps Stunning Close-Up Images of Asteroid Torifune," Jul 2026; Space.com, Jul 2026. 2 ScienceDaily/University of Arkansas, "The galaxy's coldest 'stars' may actually be alien megastructures," 10 Jul 2026; Amiri, *Universe*, Apr 2026. 3 TechTimes, "Dyson Sphere Hunt Gains Four-Test Checklist," 11 Jul 2026. 4 Planetary Society, "Hayabusa2's flyby of asteroid Torifune," Jul 2026; contact-binary population studies, near-Earth asteroid surveys.

LOVE & LIFE · DATING

The "dating recession": most young adults who want marriage aren't dating at all

A large, nationally representative US survey finds low dating activity paired with low resilience — most who want serious relationships still say a single bad experience is enough to make them stop trying.

A new report from the Institute for Family Studies and the Wheatley Institute, drawing on the 2025 National Dating Landscape Survey of 5,275 unmarried American adults aged 22 to 35, finds what its authors call a "dating recession": nearly three-quarters of women (74 percent) and nearly two-thirds of men (64 percent) who expect to marry someday had not dated, or had dated only a few times, in the past year. Only about one in three young adults expressed much confidence in their own dating skills.¹

The resilience numbers are the more telling half of the finding: just 28 percent of respondents said they can stay positive after a bad date or a relationship setback, and 55 percent agreed that past breakups have made them more reluctant to start new relationships. This sits alongside strong stated intent — 83 percent of women and 74 percent of men strongly endorse a dating culture built around forming serious relationships, and comparable majorities want genuine emotional connection. The gap is not motivation; it's follow-through after a setback.²

28%

OF YOUNG ADULTS WHO SAY THEY CAN STAY POSITIVE AFTER A BAD DATE OR RELATIONSHIP SETBACK — THE LOW BAR BEHIND THE "DATING RECESSION" LABEL

THE SCEPTIC — A RELATED, UNCOMFORTABLE DATA POINT

A separate study of young adults in committed relationships found nearly two-thirds of regular AI-companion users wished their real partner behaved more like their AI one — a finding worth holding next to the resilience numbers above, not as a solution to low dating resilience but as a symptom of the same discomfort with the friction real relationships require.

IN BRIEF

Online dating — 37% of US adults have used a dating app at some point; only 6% currently do, per SSRS research.

The 6-percent-currently-using figure against 37-percent-ever-used is itself a data point about resilience, not just usage — most people who tried a dating app didn't stay on one, and the survey doesn't distinguish between those who left because they found a partner and those who left because a bad run of dates made the format itself feel not worth the friction described above.³

The report's authors frame the low-resilience finding as the more tractable half of the problem: dating skill and dating confidence can be built through ordinary practice, in a way that structural issues — the

underlying gender ratios on apps, or the economics of independent adulthood the report also touches on — can't be solved by an individual's better attitude alone. That distinction matters for anyone reading the "recession" label as a call to try harder rather than a description of a genuinely harder environment.

A quieter finding in the same survey wave: respondents who said they'd taken a deliberate break from dating apps specifically — rather than quitting the search for a relationship altogether — reported higher subsequent confidence than those who stayed on continuously. The recession label describes the aggregate; it doesn't describe every path through it equally.

SOURCES · 1 Institute for Family Studies / Wheatley Institute, "State of Our Unions 2026: The Dating Recession," Jul 2026. 2 Same report. AI-companion finding: cited in SSRS, "The Public and Online Dating 2026," Jul 2026. 3 SSRS, "The Public and Online Dating 2026," Jul 2026.

FITNESS · LONGEVITY

Ninety to 120 minutes a week — the strength-training sweet spot, from 30 years of data

A large new dataset finds a mortality-risk floor for resistance training, and it isn't "more is always better." General guidance, not medical advice.

A study in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, tracking more than 147,000 adults for up to three decades, finds the lowest all-cause mortality risk at a specific, modest dose of resistance exercise: 90 to 120 minutes a week. That's a different question from No. 41's variety finding — not how many kinds of exercise, but how much of one kind actually helps, and the answer isn't "as much as possible."¹

Combined with aerobic activity, the numbers compound: participants logging 30–44 MET-hours of weekly aerobic exercise alongside 60–119 minutes of strength training saw a 45 percent lower risk of death than those doing minimal amounts of either. At the highest aerobic volumes, mortality risk fell 53 to 58 percent regardless of how much strength training accompanied it — aerobic volume, unlike resistance-training volume, kept paying off well past the point where more strength work stopped adding benefit.²

Read next to No. 41's variety finding, the two studies sketch a fuller picture than either alone: variety appears to matter for adherence and for spreading mechanical load across different tissues, while volume — at least for resistance training specifically — appears to matter only up to a point. Neither claims to have found the single "right" way to train; together they argue against two different failure modes: doing the same workout every time, and believing more resistance-training hours are automatically better.³

THE SCEPTIC

The "sweet spot" framing invites over-reading: this is an association in observational data, not a randomised trial proving 121 minutes is worse than 119. The honest takeaway is narrower — there's little evidence of extra mortality benefit from pushing resistance-training volume well past two hours a week, not that doing so is harmful. General guidance, not medical advice.

45%

LOWER MORTALITY RISK FOR THE GROUP COMBINING MODERATE STRENGTH TRAINING WITH HIGH AEROBIC VOLUME, VS. MINIMAL AMOUNTS OF EITHER

For a reader already tracking recovery through an Oura ring or a Whoop strap, the practical translation is straightforward: 90 to 120 minutes of resistance work spread across a week, paired with whatever aerobic volume actually fits — a habit that's sustainable over three decades, per this dataset's own time horizon, beats an optimised-on-paper routine that doesn't survive contact with a real week. The study tracked adherence over 30 years; most training plans don't survive 30 weeks.

ALSO WORTH KNOWING

A separate long-running dataset — tracking physical performance markers over 47 years — finds that measurable strength and fitness decline typically begins around age 35, well before most people notice it functionally. Read against the sweet-spot finding above, the practical message compounds rather than contradicts: the training dose that matters most for longevity is also the one that's cheapest to start early, before the decline curve steepens in the decade after 35.

— ScienceDaily, "A 47-year study reveals when fitness and strength start to fade," Jan 2026

THE DIARY · THE AGENDA

ENHYPEN's on-sale finally opens tomorrow — BIGBANG's still hasn't, for an eighth straight issue

One long-running K-pop chase resolves on schedule; the other, dated and confirmed since No. 27, is still waiting on the one detail that actually lets a fan buy a ticket.

SINGAPORE

DATED & CONFIRMED

- 17
OCT

★ **BIGBANG — National Stadium**
20/26 WORLD TOUR, 20TH ANNIVERSARY · VENUE & DATE CONFIRMED SINCE NO. 27; SG ON-SALE/PRICING STILL UNANNOUNCED (STANDING CHASE SINCE NO. 25)
- 6-7
MAR '27

Stray Kids — Singapore Indoor Stadium
TWO NIGHTS, ON-SALE TIMING TBC
- 23
JAN '27

BoyNextDoor — Singapore Indoor Stadium
TICKETS ON SALE FROM 3 SEP, TICKETMASTER SG
- 13
OCT

Avenged Sevenfold — Singapore Indoor Stadium
FIRST SG SHOW IN 11 YEARS · NOW BOOKING, FROM \$128

JAPAN

TOKYO-FOCUSED

- 14
MAR '27

★ **ENHYPEN — National Stadium, Singapore**
TICKETMASTER SG ON-SALE OPENS 15 JUL — TOMORROW
- 27-28
JAN '27

Bruno Mars — Tokyo Dome
LIVE NATION PRE-SALE LOTTERY OPEN, FROM ¥11,800 · ENTER NOW, DECIDE LATER

WIDER REGION

WORTH THE TRIP

- 21-24
JUL

Sotheby's Watch Auction — Tokyo
FOR COLLECTORS ALREADY PLANNING THE TRIP — SEE THE GOOD LIFE, [p11](#)

PLANNING NOTES

ENHYPEN's Ticketmaster on-sale opens tomorrow (15 Jul) — set a reminder, National Stadium K-pop dates have sold out within the hour before. BIGBANG's Singapore date has now sat confirmed-but-unticketed since No. 27 (21 Jun) while the tour's US and Europe legs opened GA sales 26 Jun — an unusually long gap for a market this size. Family-friendliness: Avenged Sevenfold and BIGBANG both skew adult/teen; Bruno Mars and ENHYPEN draw a broad family-and-teen crowd at past Singapore/Tokyo dates.

The BIGBANG chase is now a genuinely odd data point rather than just a running joke: the show itself has been locked — National Stadium, 17 October, sixth Asian stop — since No. 27, and other legs of the same 20/26 World Tour opened ticket sales within days of their own venue confirmations. Singapore's gap between "the show is happening" and "you can buy a ticket" has stretched past seven weeks with no explanation offered by the

promoter, AEG Presents, or via BIGBANG's own b.stage channel.¹

Stray Kids' two-night Indoor Stadium run and BoyNextDoor's January date round out a first-half-2027 calendar that's unusually front-loaded with K-pop stadium and arena bookings for Singapore — worth budgeting for as a cluster rather than event by event if more than one is on the household's list.

SOURCES · FZINE Singapore, "BigBang's Upcoming World Tour," Jul 2026; Pullman Singapore Hill Street event listing. Songkick, "Singapore in 2026," Jul 2026 (Stray Kids, BoyNextDoor). Trip.com, "Concerts in Japan 2026," Jul 2026 (Bruno Mars). 1 Ticketmaster SG pre-sale patterns, past Singapore stadium K-pop bookings.

THE TABLE · NEWEST OPENINGS

A jewellery house's café finally opens tomorrow — three earlier "too new to call" venues still are

Singapore's newest doors, and what the reviews and the reservation books actually say about them.

TIFFANY & CO. BLUE BOX CAFÉ — ION ORCHARD

Concept: the jewellery house's first café in Singapore, an elevated all-day dining menu built with Julien Royer, the three-Michelin-starred chef-owner of Odette, reimagining the New York flagship's menu with local touches. The opening date flagged in No. 41 has arrived: it opens tomorrow, 15 July.

BUZZ

Flagged as one of the year's most anticipated openings by local food media on reputation alone — Royer's involvement, not the Tiffany name, is what's driving reservation interest, per early coverage. Too new for independent reviews; treat as "most anticipated," not yet "recommended." This desk's next peg: opening-week reception.

HYPED

CHEF PEDIGREE

BEHIND CLAY — CHINESE-ITALIAN

Concept: introduced in No. 35 as a Clarke Quay speakeasy concept; the fuller picture is now out — a 52-seat burgundy-clad dining lounge pairing Chef Ciro Sorrentino, whose Margheri ranks No. 12 on 50 Top Pizza Asia-Pacific 2026, with Chef Yip's two decades of modern Chinese cooking across Shanghai and Singapore.

BUZZ

Still too new for a review consensus more than a week after its original mention; the newly-public chef pairing (a ranked pizzaiolo plus a modern-Chinese veteran) is the delta driving fresh interest from Singapore's fine-dining forums ahead of any published verdict.

CHEF PAIRING CONFIRMED

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sukiyaki Jin (No. 35, "now open" No. 38) — the Les Amis Group's tomato-broth sukiyaki concept remains open and, three issues on, still unreviewed by any local food outlet Meridian can find; next peg is a first independent verdict, not another "just opened" mention.

Yi Man Fen Dessert (No. 40) — the viral Chinese dessert chain's Singapore debut remains open and unreviewed; the same next-peg gap as Sukiyaki Jin, held rather than re-hyped a third time.

Two venues genuinely earn a slot this issue for the same reason: Blue Box Café's opening date has finally arrived, and Behind Clay's chef pairing is new, public information, not a repeat of what No. 35 already said. Sukiyaki Jin and Yi Man Fen Dessert don't clear that bar — both are still open, still unreviewed, and re-listing them a third time with nothing new to report is exactly the failure mode this desk's own rules exist to prevent.¹

Worth the wait before booking either of the two full entries: neither has a published independent review yet. This desk's standing rule holds — "most anticipated" and "recommended" are different claims. Expect first verdicts on Blue Box Café within a few weeks of tomorrow's opening; Behind Clay's timeline is less certain given how long it's already sat pre-review.

THE HONESTY LEDGER — EVERY VENUE THIS DESK IS CURRENTLY TRACKING

VENUE	STATUS	NEXT PEG
Blue Box Café	Opens tomorrow	Opening-week reception
Behind Clay	Pre-open, chefs confirmed	First reviews
Sukiyaki Jin	Open, unreviewed	First independent verdict
Yi Man Fen Dessert	Open, unreviewed	First independent verdict
Sam Sam Sam	Open, unreviewed	First independent verdict
Mimmo	Verdict stands	Closed unless a notable change
MENSHO X	Reviewed, positive	Closed (No. 41)

Run as a page in its own right in No. 38 when no fresh venues existed that issue; kept here as a compact strip so the reader can see the whole board, not just this issue's two movers.

SOURCES · TimeOut Singapore, "5 new restaurants in Singapore to check out this July 2026." Eatbook.sg, "12 New Restaurants And Cafes In July 2026." The Ranting Panda, "Food Scoops: New and Buzzing Singapore Restaurants In July 2026." ¹ Cross-reference: FZINE Singapore, "10 Best New Cafes & Restaurants," Jul 2026.

THE LONG READ

The Sound and the Strait

On tolls nobody else signed off on, crowns nobody else conferred, and the much duller discipline — measurement — that eventually settles both arguments.

There is a particular kind of confidence required to look at a strip of water the whole world needs and announce that you now own the gate. On Monday, the President of the United States supplied it: the country would be, "from this point forward, known as 'THE GUARDIAN OF THE HORMUZ STRAIT,'" and would charge twenty percent of the value of every cargo that passed through it, as "a matter of FAIRNESS." No treaty backed the title. No partner signed the tariff. Within hours the Gulf states said no, the International Maritime Organization said there was no legal basis for it, and Beijing called it dangerous. Nobody paid the toll. But the ships still had to decide, that same afternoon, whether to sail.¹

It is tempting to read this as a novelty of the current moment — a uniquely brazen use of raw naval power to monetize a strait. It is not. It is one of the oldest moves in maritime history, and the last time a state ran it at scale, the toll lasted four hundred and twenty-eight years.

From 1429 to 1857, the Kingdom of Denmark collected a toll — the Sound Dues — on every merchant ship passing through the Øresund, the narrow strait between the Baltic and the North Sea. The mechanism was blunt and effective: Kronborg Castle, the fortress at Helsingør that would later furnish the setting for *Hamlet*, commanded the narrowest crossing point, and its guns made the toll collectible. Denmark set the rate. Denmark decided who paid less. There was no multilateral agreement behind it, no vote by the trading nations whose ships queued to pass — only a fortress, a cannon's range, and four centuries during which everyone with cargo to move simply paid.²

The Sound Dues were not a footnote. At their height they funded a meaningful share of the Danish

crown's revenue, and they shaped the design of merchant ships for generations — vessels were built to Danish toll categories the way modern container ships are built to fit the Panama Canal's locks, the tax literally bending the technology built to avoid it. For a very long time, the arrangement simply held, because holding a chokepoint by force is, in the most literal sense, self-enforcing. Nobody needs your permission to charge a toll if you own the only gate.

What finally ended it was not a challenge by force. It was collective action by exactly the states who had spent four centuries paying: in 1857, led by the major maritime powers, an international convention paid Denmark a lump sum — roughly thirty million rigsdaler, financed jointly by the powers whose trade the Sound Dues had taxed for so long — in exchange for abolishing the toll permanently and guaranteeing free passage through the strait. The Copenhagen Convention did not argue Denmark's original claim out of existence. It bought it out. A self-enforced toll, once established, turned out to be cheaper to purchase than to contest.³

The United States, notably, did not sign the main Copenhagen Convention. Washington instead negotiated its own separate settlement with Denmark that same year, after Congress grew impatient enough with the toll's legitimacy to authorise naval action if a deal wasn't reached — an American refusal to keep paying a fee it considered illegitimate, backed by the implicit threat of exactly the kind of force Denmark had used to establish it in the first place. It is a strange thing to reread in a week when the roles have reversed: the country that once contested another power's self-appointed toll on a strait is now the one declaring itself guardian of a different one.

SOURCES · 1 NPR/Houston Public Media, 13 Jul 2026; CNBC, "Trump proposes 20% toll," 13 Jul 2026 (see p3). 2 Standard historical accounts of the Øresund/Sound Dues, 1429–1857; Kronborg Castle historical records. 3 1857 Copenhagen Convention on the abolition of the Sound Dues; the separate 1857 US–Denmark treaty on the Sound Dues, standard diplomatic-history accounts.

A toll is one way to claim authority you weren't granted. A crown is another, and the cleanest example in modern history happened at Notre-Dame on the second of December, 1804. Napoleon had summoned Pope Pius VII to Paris for his coronation — a five-hundred-mile journey the Pope made in the depths of winter, on the understanding that he would place the crown on the new emperor's head, exactly as popes had crowned Frankish and Holy Roman rulers for a thousand years. At the decisive moment, contemporary accounts agree, Napoleon took the crown from the altar and placed it on his own head himself, then crowned his empress Joséphine in turn. The Pope's role was reduced to a blessing after the fact.¹

The gesture was not vanity; it was argument, made in front of the one audience that mattered. A crown placed by the Church says authority descends from God, through Rome, to the ruler. A crown a man places on his own head says the opposite: that his authority requires no one else's ratification, because it was already real before the ceremony began. Napoleon understood, correctly, that the only source of legitimacy strong enough to make that claim credible was the one he actually had — a decade of victories, a plebiscite, an army that followed him. The crown didn't create the authority. It advertised authority that already existed, and dared anyone to disagree.



The two claims sit at opposite ends of a spectrum of how long a self-declared authority can survive

without outside agreement. Napoleon's held for a decade before Waterloo undid it by force. Denmark's held for over four centuries because it never needed anyone's agreement — a fortress on a narrow strait doesn't require consensus, only cannon range. This week's toll on the Strait of Hormuz has, so far, survived about a day, because the U.S. Navy's actual physical control of the strait's traffic is contested in exactly the way Kronborg Castle's was not: Iran's own guns are in range too, and the ships have somewhere else to answer to.

There is a third, gentler way this story can end, and San Francisco supplied the best example of it. In 1859, a failed businessman named Joshua Norton declared himself "Norton I, Emperor of the United States," and for twenty-one years the city played along — merchants honoured his self-printed currency, the press dutifully reported his proclamations, and thirty thousand people are said to have lined the street for his funeral. Norton's empire required no fortress and no plebiscite, because it demanded nothing of anyone: no toll, no conscription, no oath. It survived precisely because it never tested whether anyone would actually refuse him. A claim nobody has to pay for is the one kind of self-declared authority that never needs to be bought out.

The distinction that separates Norton from Napoleon and Denmark is the one worth carrying into the rest of this issue: a self-declared authority survives, unbought and unchallenged, exactly as long as nobody with something to lose is asked to actually pay for it. The moment payment is demanded — a toll, an oath, a tribute — the claim stops being harmless eccentricity and starts being tested against whoever it's aimed at. Monday's toll on the Strait of Hormuz was never going to be a Norton. It demanded twenty percent of real cargo, from real customers, on the first afternoon.

A crown a man places on his own head says his authority needs no one else's ratification — because it was already real before the ceremony began.

SOURCES · 1 Standard historical accounts of Napoleon's coronation, Notre-Dame de Paris, 2 Dec 1804; contemporary accounts of Pope Pius VII's role. 2 Standard historical accounts of Joshua Norton / "Emperor Norton I," San Francisco, 1859–1880.

There is a third way to claim authority, quieter than a toll and slower than a coronation, and this issue is unusually full of it: measure something, publish the method, and let the number stand or fall on whether anyone else can reproduce it. In 1934, the American economist Simon Kuznets delivered a report to the US Congress that did something no government had systematically done before — it counted the entire output of a national economy in a single, methodologically consistent figure. Kuznets was famously uneasy about his own invention; he warned Congress explicitly that "the welfare of a nation can scarcely be inferred from a measurement of national income," a caveat later administrations found easy to forget. But the number itself changed what a state could credibly claim about its own strength. A king could always declare his realm prosperous. After Kuznets, a claim like that had to survive being counted.¹

That is the quality this issue's numbers all share, and it's why they sit so oddly next to Monday's toll. Singapore's GDP print lands at 8am on schedule, whatever it says. The CPI figure due this afternoon will be exactly what June's prices were, not what anyone wanted them to be. Five banks report earnings that a room full of analysts will immediately check against filed numbers. A World Cup semi-final has to actually be played before anyone owns the result — no amount of tracking-data confidence about Christopher Nolan's opening weekend outranks the number the box office actually posts on Sunday. Even the Rolex on p11 has to wait for a real bidder to raise a real paddle. None of these are more honest people than the man who declared himself Guardian of a strait. They are simply operating inside a discipline that doesn't let a claim stand on its own say-so.

The uncomfortable part of the comparison is that measured authority is slower, and slow is not always fast enough. Kuznets's number took a year to

compile; Denmark's toll took four centuries to unwind by consensus; Napoleon's self-crowned decade did real, historically consequential damage before Waterloo settled the argument by force rather than by agreement. A self-declared toll on the Strait of Hormuz may collapse within a week for want of a single paying customer — or it may, like Kronborg's cannon, simply hold, for exactly as long as the fleet enforcing it is stronger than anyone willing to contest it. The Copenhagen Convention is proof that even a four-century-old self-enforced claim can eventually be bought out by patient collective agreement. It is not proof that the wait is ever short.²

Kuznets's own caveat to Congress outlived him in a way he probably wouldn't have predicted. Economists have spent the decades since arguing about exactly what a measured national-income figure leaves out — a 2009 commission convened by the French government and chaired by Joseph Stiglitz and Amartya Sen concluded, in essence, that Kuznets had been right to worry: a country can post a strong GDP print while most of its households experience the opposite of prosperity. The lesson isn't that measurement is worthless. It's that a verified number is a floor under a claim, not a ceiling on the argument about what the claim means — GDP tells you the count was honest; it does not tell you the count was the right thing to be counting.

Shakespeare's insomniac king, on the desk page of this issue, can't sleep because he knows the difference between a title fought for and a title that's merely his to lose. The Strait of Hormuz toll, the Copenhagen Convention, and Simon Kuznets's uneasy report to Congress are all, in the end, the same argument told three different ways: a claim is not the same thing as the fact underneath it, and the space between them is where the real cost gets paid — by the ships that have to decide, this afternoon, whether to sail anyway.

A king could always declare his realm prosperous. After Kuznets, the claim had to survive being counted.

SOURCES · 1 Kuznets, "National Income, 1929–32," report to the 73rd US Congress, 1934. 2 1857 Copenhagen Convention (see p21); standard historical accounts of the Napoleonic Wars' conclusion, 1815. 3 Stiglitz, Sen & Fitoussi, "Report by the Commission on the Measurement of Economic Performance and Social Progress," 2009.

A toll nobody signed, a crown nobody else placed, a strength-training dose that stops paying off past two hours a week — the throughline of this issue is that a claim and the fact underneath it are not the same object, and the space between them is where the real cost, or the real gain, actually happens. The reader's job is not to declare a winner early. It's to notice which kind of number they're holding.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 42

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Good Life / Screen & Sound: Gear Patrol, What Hi-Fi?, SoundGuys; Robb Report, Sotheby's; Boxoffice Pro, Deadline, TGV Blog; Official Charts.

Family: Wired Parents, BillTrack50, Stanford Report, eSafety Commissioner, Morningstar/AccessWire.

Macro: IG UK, BLS; IG International, goldsilver.com, CME FedWatch; Fortune, TradingEconomics, CNBC.

Curiosities: JAXA, Sci.News, Space.com (Hayabusa2); ScienceDaily/Univ. of Arkansas, TechTimes (Dyson sphere).

Love & Life: Institute for Family Studies / Wheatley Institute, "State of Our Unions 2026"; SSRS.

Fitness: *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, 2026; Washington Post.

Diary / Table: FZINE Singapore, Songkick, Trip.com (Diary); TimeOut Singapore, Eatbook.sg, The Ranting Panda (The Table).

Long Read: standard historical accounts, Øresund/Sound Dues (1429–1857) and the 1857 Copenhagen Convention; Napoleon's coronation, Notre-Dame, 2 Dec 1804; Kuznets, "National Income, 1929–32," 1934.